SURPRISE PACKAGE



Rajasthan CM **Bhajan Lal Sharma** has been a revelation, delivering over 50 more urban local bodies other than what the BJP won (148 boards) in the September civic polls, expertly 'engineering' support where the party fell short. Back on the campaign trail for the panchayat elections, the first-time MLA and CM has elicited a variety of reactions from all sides. Ex-CM Ashok Gehlot said he never expected such "misuse of government machinery" from a "simple man" like Sharma. Must count as high praise, coming from the wily Congressman.

BREAKING RANK



On October 3, the Janata Dal (United) declared party spokesman Neeraj Kumar as the ruling NDA's nominee for the Patna Graduates' seat in the coming Bihar Legislative Council election. But that hasn't stopped Mokama strongman and JD(U) MLA **Anant Singh's** vociferous campaign for rival Jan Suraaj candidate, Anuj Singh. It is the first serious challenge to the party since its president **Nitish Kumar** stepped down as chief minister in April, and there has been no response so far. No show-cause, no rap on the knuckles; the senior leaders are all in wait-and-watch mode.



FISHING FOR RATNAS



The Bharat Ratna reccos have found a new route, through Bengal politics. The little known Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI) has mooted chief election commissioner **Gyanesh Kumar's** name for India's highest civilian honour, praising his efforts in the "peaceful and credible" 2026 West Bengal poll. It's an odd assessment, especially with the Opposition out for Kumar's head over the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) imbroglio. There is some soul-searching in the NCPI too—Lok Sabha MP Yusuf Pathan, one of the 20 who switched over from the Trinamool Congress, says he never wrote any such recommendation.

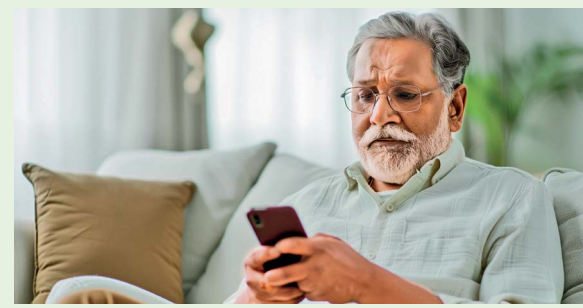
Prasad Nichenametla, Avaneesh Mishra, Rohit Parihar, Amitabh Srivastava *and* Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

HEALTH WATCH

DIGITAL APPS LEAVING ELDERS BEHIND

By **Sonali Acharjee**

India tends to think of the digital divide as a problem of access: give someone a smartphone, teach them how to use it, and the problem is solved. A new study suggests it may not be that simple. Published online on September 26 in *The American Journal of Geriatric Psychiatry*, the study followed 100 adults aged 60 to 85 in Lucknow and Hardoi. It found that difficulty using apps, lack of technical support and complicated interfaces were more closely linked with digital isolation than age itself. Only 13 per cent of the participants could access health reports independently, while 44-45 per cent often felt befuddled by the technology.



Another Indian study, published in April in *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications*, looked at 218 elders in Pune. It found that being digitally literate did not necessarily make people more willing to use tech. What mattered strongly was whether it felt easy and useful.

This is of particular concern in India, where the elderly population is growing rapidly even as banking, health reports, payments, tickets and government services are moving on to apps. A badly designed interface can therefore become more than an inconvenience; it can become a barrier to healthcare, money, mobility and social contact. In fact, digital isolation was associated with loneliness. Experts say the answer is not just more digital literacy classes. Apps also need larger text, simpler navigation, fewer steps, vernacular options and easy recovery when something goes wrong. Poor design may not just frustrate older users, it may quietly shut them out of everyday life.